

08 Semantic HTML: All the Tags

Landmarks · Content sectioning · Accessibility

What semantic HTML means

Semantic markup describes **what** the content is, not merely how it looks. To a browser, `<div class="header">` is just a generic box, whereas `<header>` is a recognised landmark that assistive technology and search engines both understand.

Layout landmarks

Tag	Usage
<code><header></code>	Introductory content such as a logo, site title or the heading area of a page. It may appear more than once, since each <code><article></code> can have its own header.
<code><nav></code>	A block of major navigation links. Not every group of links needs it; reserve it for primary and secondary navigation.
<code><main></code>	The main, unique content of the page. There should be only one <code><main></code> per page and it must not be nested inside other landmarks. The “skip to content” feature jumps here.
<code><article></code>	Self-contained content that still makes sense on its own, such as a blog post, a product card, a comment or a news item.
<code><section></code>	A thematic grouping of content. Each section should have its own heading ; without one, a <code><div></code> is the better choice.
<code><aside></code>	Tangential content such as a sidebar, related links, advertisements or an author biography.
<code><footer></code>	Closing information such as copyright, contact details and secondary links.

Content-level semantic tags

Tag	Usage
<code><figure></code> , <code><figcaption></code>	An image, diagram or code listing together with its caption, treated as a single unit.
<code><time datetime="2026-08-18"></code>	A machine-readable date, used by search engines for publication dates and events.
<code><address></code>	Contact details of the author or organisation, not an arbitrary postal address.
<code><details></code> , <code><summary></code>	A native expand and collapse control that needs no JavaScript.
<code><dialog></code>	A native modal dialogue box.
<code><progress></code> , <code><meter></code>	Progress of a task, and a measurement within a known range such as disk usage.
<code><div></code> , <code></code>	Non-semantic containers, used purely for styling or grouping when no suitable semantic element exists.

A typical semantic layout

```
<body>
  <header>
    <nav><ul><li><a href="/">Home</a></li></ul></nav>
  </header>

  <main>
    <article>
      <h1>Post title</h1>
      <time datetime="2026-08-18">18 August 2026</time>
      <section><h2>Introduction</h2><p>...</p></section>
    </article>
    <aside><h2>Related reading</h2></aside>
  </main>

  <footer><p>&copy; 2026</p></footer>
</body>
```

CHOOSING BETWEEN SECTION, ARTICLE AND DIV

If the content would still make sense when moved elsewhere, such as into a feed, use `<article>`. If it is a thematic part of the page with its own heading, use `<section>`. If it exists only to be styled, use `<div>`.

COMMON MISTAKES

Turning every wrapper into a `<section>` · placing two `<main>` elements on one page · sections without headings · building clickable elements as `<div onclick>`, which cannot be reached by keyboard, where a `<button>` belongs · marking navigation as `<div class="nav">`.

QUICK RECAP

- Landmarks describe the regions of a page and make it navigable without sight.
- A `<section>` earns its place only when it has a heading.
- Interactive elements must be genuinely interactive elements, not styled containers.